

GRACE NOTES

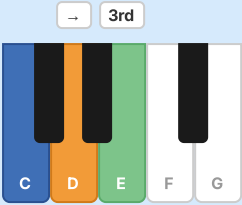
Chromatic approach tones that add expression and flavor at the onset of chord tones.

WHAT A GRACE NOTE IS

A grace note quickly plays a note *leading into* a chord tone at the onset of the chord — like a brief approach that resolves immediately into the target note. It adds expression, bluesy feel, and life to chord attacks. Three patterns cover 90% of situations.

MAJOR & MAJ7 CHORDS

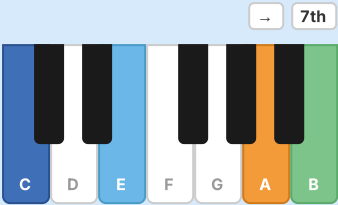
— Cmaj7, Fmaj7, etc.



2 → 3

D slides into E

Approach the major 3rd from below by one whole step. Bright, jazzy grace — creates a lift into the chord.



6 → 7

A slides into B

Approach the major 7th from below by one whole step. Soulful, warm feel — works especially well in slow ballads.

2 → 3 or 6 → 7

MINOR & MIN7 CHORDS

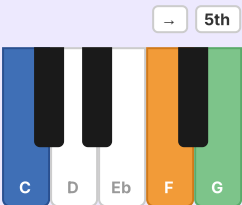
— Dm7, Am7, Cm7, etc.



2 → b3

D slides into Eb (on Cm7)

Whole step approach into the minor 3rd. Captures the blues tension between major and minor. Most expressive minor grace.



4 → 5

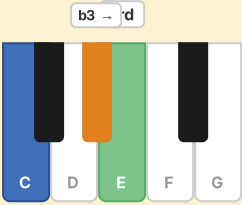
F slides into G

Approach the 5th from below by a whole step. Slightly more subtle — adds rhythmic articulation without the blues flavor.

2 → b3 or 4 → 5

DOMINANT CHORDS

— G7, C7, F7, etc.



b3 → 3

Eb slides into E (on C7)

The blues grace note — approaching the major 3rd from a half step below using the flat third. This is THE characteristic dominant blues move. Sounds like classic R&B and blues piano.

b3 → 3 (the blues grace)

WHY GRACE NOTES WORK

Grace notes are chromatic approach tones. They work because the ear hears the *motion into* the chord tone — not the dissonance of the passing note itself. The faster the grace note, the stronger the arrival on the chord tone feels. Use them at chord attacks for color, not as sustained notes.